SPORTS ANALYTICS

Spending, Selling and Pressing: An Analytical Review of AS Roma under the Friedkin Ownership, 2020–2026

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ABSTRACT

This paper evaluates how AS Roma has converted money into results since The Friedkin Group acquired the club in August 2020. It combines public financial statements, wage data for every Serie A club, transfer records, expected-goals data and match statistics to assess the club through six lenses: financial position, wage efficiency against the rest of Serie A, transfer spending, academy strategy, on-pitch performance, and a live recruitment decision. Roma's owners provided €824m of funding over six seasons while the club remained under a UEFA settlement agreement. A log-wage model explains roughly two-thirds of the variation in Serie A points, and by that model Roma finished a combined 15 points below its wage-implied expectation in the three seasons before 2025/26, almost all of it in 2022/23 and 2023/24. Of the 13 transfer signings costing €10m or more that are old enough to judge, only three became core starters, measured by share of available league minutes. Academy sales raised about €57m and served as a source of liquidity under regulatory pressure, most clearly in June 2023. Gian Piero Gasperini's third-place finish in 2025/26 matched the wage model's expectation rather than exceeding it, and outran the club's underlying expected-goals performance by about seven points. The paper closes by applying these findings to Roma's weakest position.

Keywords: sports analytics · wage efficiency · transfer market · expected goals · financial sustainability · recruitment modelling

KEY FINDINGS

1. **Wages set the expectation, and Roma underdelivered on it.** Roma had the third- or fourth-highest wage bill in Serie A in each of the four seasons measured, but finished 6th, 6th and 5th, a combined 15 points below its wage-implied total from 2022/23 to 2024/25, mostly in the first two of those seasons.
2. **Gasperini's third place was par, not an overachievement.** In 2025/26 Roma finished +0.8 points against its wage expectation, but about 7 points above what its expected-goal difference would predict.
3. **Fee-based recruitment underperformed.** Three of 13 €10m+ signings became core starters, while four free agents played 28,437 league minutes and two of them (Svilar and Ndicka) are now valued at about €76m combined.
4. **The academy financed compliance.** Academy sales raised about €57m, but the share of league minutes given to academy graduates fell from 17.3% in 2022/23 to 7.4% in 2025/26.
5. **Financial pressure persists.** Wages still consumed 67% of operating revenue in 2024/25. Roma was fined €6m by UEFA in June 2026 and remains under monitoring. The approved Pietralata stadium is the largest available lever for closing the revenue gap with Inter, Milan and Juventus.

1. Introduction

Professional football clubs make large, irreversible investments under uncertainty. A transfer fee is a capital expenditure on an asset whose value depends on performance, health, playing time and the decisions of the coaching staff, and whose resale price is set in a thin, negotiated market. Wages are a larger and stickier commitment still. Clubs must also comply with UEFA's financial regulations, which link spending to revenue. For a club without the commercial scale of Europe's richest sides, the quality of these decisions largely determines whether it competes for trophies or merely survives.

AS Roma is an informative case. When The Friedkin Group bought the club from James Pallotta in August 2020, Roma had not won Serie A since 2001 and had finished between fifth and seventh in each of the previous two seasons. The new owners funded heavy losses (€185m in 2020/21 and €220m in 2021/22), won the inaugural UEFA Europa Conference League in 2022, entered a UEFA settlement agreement that restricted spending, and employed six head coaches in six seasons. In 2025/26, under Gian Piero Gasperini, the club finished third and returned to the Champions League.

This paper asks a simple question with a complicated answer: *how effectively has Roma turned money into results, and what should it do next?* It approaches the question through six connected lenses, each corresponding to a decision area that a club's analytics department would support: the club's financial position (Section 3); its efficiency relative to its wage bill, benchmarked against every Serie A club

(Section 4); transfer spending and asset value (Section 5); the academy (Section 6); on-pitch performance, including underlying expected-goals data, pressing and squad age (Section 7); and a concrete recruitment recommendation (Section 8).

2. Data and Methods

Sources. Financial figures come from Roma's published accounts as reported by Calcio e Finanza and the Swiss Ramble, and owner funding totals from Calcio e Finanza's 2026 summary of the Friedkin investment. Gross player wage bills for all Serie A clubs come from Calcio e Finanza (2024/25 and 2025/26), Calciomercato.com (2023/24) and OA Sport (2022/23); final points come from official league tables. Transfer fees were compiled from Sky Sport Italia's window-by-window record of the January 2021 to January 2024 period, Salary Sport and Foot Mercato for later seasons, and Chiesa di Totti for summer 2020. Player minutes come from FBref's Serie A squad pages. Expected-goals (xG) data come from Understat shot data, FBref's Opta tables and StatMuse. Pressing data come from Assoanalisti's analysis of Understat, Gazzetta dello Sport, Opta and SofaScore. Market values and recruitment data come from FotMob as of October 2026. All values are in euros.

Wage efficiency. Research in football economics consistently finds that wage spending is the strongest single predictor of league performance. For each season with complete data (2022/23 to 2025/26), points were regressed on the natural logarithm of each club's wage bill relative to the league average:

$$\text{Points}_i = \alpha + \beta \cdot \ln(\text{Wage}_i \div \text{mean league wage}) + \varepsilon_i$$

The residual ε measures how many points a club earned above or below the level its wage bill predicts, and serves as a measure of how efficiently the club, including its coaching staff and recruitment, converted wages into results.

Underlying performance. Expected goals estimate the quality of chances created and conceded. For 2019/20 to 2023/24, Roma's expected points were simulated match by match from Understat shot data. For 2024/25 and 2025/26, where complete shot data were unavailable, expected points were estimated by regressing all 20 clubs' points on their xG difference (xG minus xG against) and reading off Roma's fitted value.

Signing returns. Each signing of €10m or more is evaluated using a position-neutral measure of how much the club used the player it paid for:

Minutes share = Roma Serie A minutes ÷ (seasons owned × 3,420 available minutes)
Net cost per 1,000 minutes = (fee − money recovered from sales and loan fees) ÷ (Roma Serie A minutes ÷ 1,000)

Seasons spent on loan elsewhere count as owned seasons, because Roma still carried the cost of the registration. Signings are classified as *core starters* (60% or more of available minutes), *regulars* (35–60%), *rotation* players (15–35%) or *flops* (under 15%). Pressing intensity is measured with PPDA (opponent passes allowed per defensive action), where a lower value indicates more aggressive pressing.

3. Financial Context

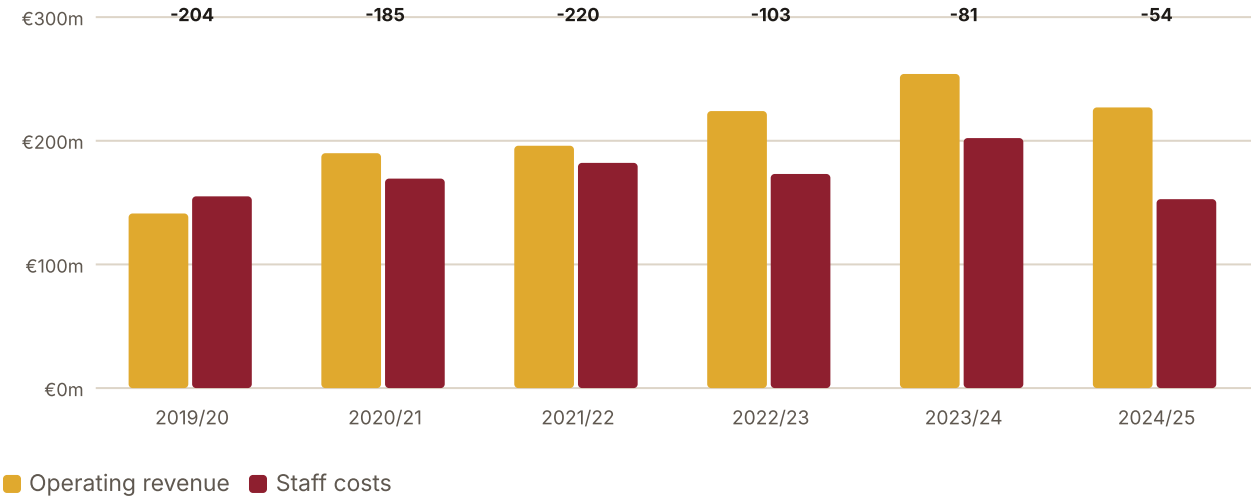
Every other finding in this paper sits inside a financial constraint. Table 1 summarises Roma's accounts from the last pre-Friedkin season onward.

Table 1. Roma financial summary by fiscal year (€m, year ending 30 June)

Fiscal year	Operating revenue	Staff costs	Wages ÷ revenue	Net result	Owner funding
2019/20	141	155	110%	-204	–
2020/21	190	169	89%	-185	163
2021/22	196	182	93%	-220	206
2022/23	224	173	77%	-103	232
2023/24	254	202	80%	-81	90
2024/25	227	153	67%	-54	82

Operating revenue excludes player trading. 2019/20 precedes the takeover and was affected by the pandemic. Wages ÷ revenue is the author's calculation. Owner funding for 2025/26 (about €50m to date) is not yet in published accounts; the €824m total cited in the text includes it. Source: Roma accounts via Calcio e Finanza and the Swiss Ramble; Calcio e Finanza (2026).

Figure 1. Operating revenue and staff costs by fiscal year, €m (net result shown above each pair)



Source: Roma accounts via Calcio e Finanza and the Swiss Ramble.

Three features stand out. First, staff costs exceeded 89% of operating revenue in each of the first two seasons of the ownership, a level at which no club can break even without large player-trading profits or owner support. The Friedkins supplied that support: €824m of funding between 2020/21 and 2025/26, and about €1.05bn including the purchase of the club. Second, the ratio has improved, reaching 67% in 2024/25, and the annual loss has narrowed from €220m to €54m. Third, revenue growth has stalled: operating revenue peaked at about €254m in 2023/24, helped by a run to the Europa League semi-finals, and fell back to €227m in 2024/25.

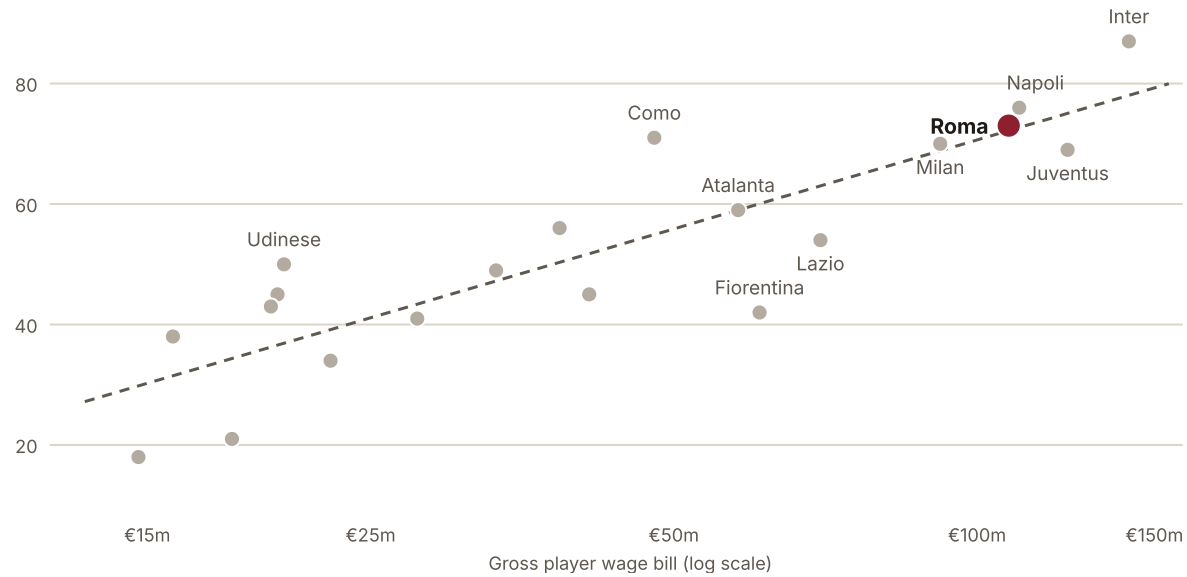
Regulatory constraint. In September 2022 UEFA placed Roma under a four-year settlement agreement for breaching its break-even rules, with a €35m financial contribution (€5m unconditional), annual targets and limits on registering new players. Roma paid further fines of €2m and €3m for the following seasons, and in October 2025 UEFA extended the agreement to June 2027. In June 2026 UEFA fined the club another €6m for narrowly missing its football-earnings target and for squad costs above 70% of revenue in 2025. UEFA's squad-cost ratio is broader than the wage ratio in Table 1, since it also includes player amortisation and agents' fees, which is why Roma can breach a 70% squad-cost limit while its wages alone are 67% of revenue. Inter and Milan have exited their settlement agreements; Roma has not. This matters for interpretation: the heavy spending of 2024–2026 took place *within* a regulatory regime, not after one.

The revenue gap. According to Deloitte's Football Money League, which uses a slightly different revenue definition from the club accounts in Table 1, Roma's 2024/25 revenue of €216m compared with €538m for Inter, €410m for Milan and €402m for Juventus. Matchday income is the clearest structural weakness: €44m in 2024/25, generated in a stadium Roma rents. On 28 September 2026 the club received final authorisation for its new stadium at Pietralata, a €1.38bn project with a planned capacity of about 60,600, targeted for completion in 2031. The project's own projections put first-year stadium revenue at about €154m, more than three times current matchday income. Even if those projections prove optimistic, the stadium is the largest single lever available for closing the gap with Serie A's revenue leaders.

4. Wage Efficiency: Roma against Serie A

Because wages predict results so strongly, a fair evaluation of any club must start from what its wage bill should deliver. Figure 2 plots every Serie A club's gross player wages against its points in 2025/26, with the fitted log-wage curve.

Figure 2. Gross player wage bill and league points, Serie A 2025/26



Each point is one club; the dashed line is the fitted log-wage model (R^2 = 0.75). Clubs above the line earned more points than their wage bill predicts. Source: Calcio e Finanza; official league table; author's model.

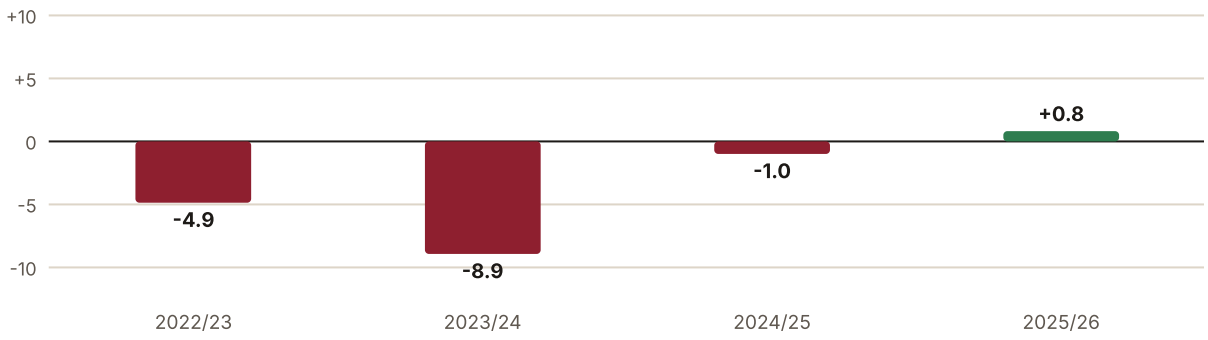
The model fits well. Across the four seasons, log wages explain between 57% and 75% of the variation in points (67% pooled), and doubling a club's wage bill relative to the league is associated with about 15 additional points. Table 2 shows Roma's position against that benchmark.

Table 2. Roma's league performance against its wage-implied expectation

Season	Head coach	Wage bill	Wage rank	Expected pts	Actual pts	Residual	Model R^2
2022/23	Mourinho	€86m	4	67.9	63	**-4.9**	0.64
2023/24	Mourinho → De Rossi	€107m	3	71.9	63	**-8.9**	0.57
2024/25	De Rossi → Jurić → Ranieri	€90m	4	70.0	69	**-1.0**	0.74
2025/26	Gasperini	€108m	4	72.2	73	**+0.8**	0.75

Gross annual player wages, pre-season estimates. Source: Calcio e Finanza, Calciomercato.com, OA Sport; author's model.

Figure 3. Roma's points above or below wage expectation, by season



Source: author's model, Table 2.

The result reframes the club's recent history. Roma's wage bill ranked third or fourth in Serie A in every season measured, which implies a natural finishing position of roughly third or fourth. Under Mourinho, De Rossi, Jurić and Ranieri the club fell short of that expectation in each season, by 15 points in total, while clubs such as Atalanta, Bologna and Napoli repeatedly finished well above the line. Most of that shortfall came in 2022/23 and 2023/24. It closed in 2024/25, when Ranieri's rescue run left Roma just one point short of expectation, and Gasperini's third place in 2025/26 (+0.8) maintained that level rather than surpassing it. The improvement since 2024 is therefore better described as the end of underperformance than as overachievement. That distinction matters for expectations: on this evidence, Roma's wage bill supports a top-four finish, but not a title challenge. For 2026/27 the club cut its gross wage bill to about €93m, the fifth-highest in Serie A.

5. Capital Allocation: The Transfer Ledger

5.1 Spending over time

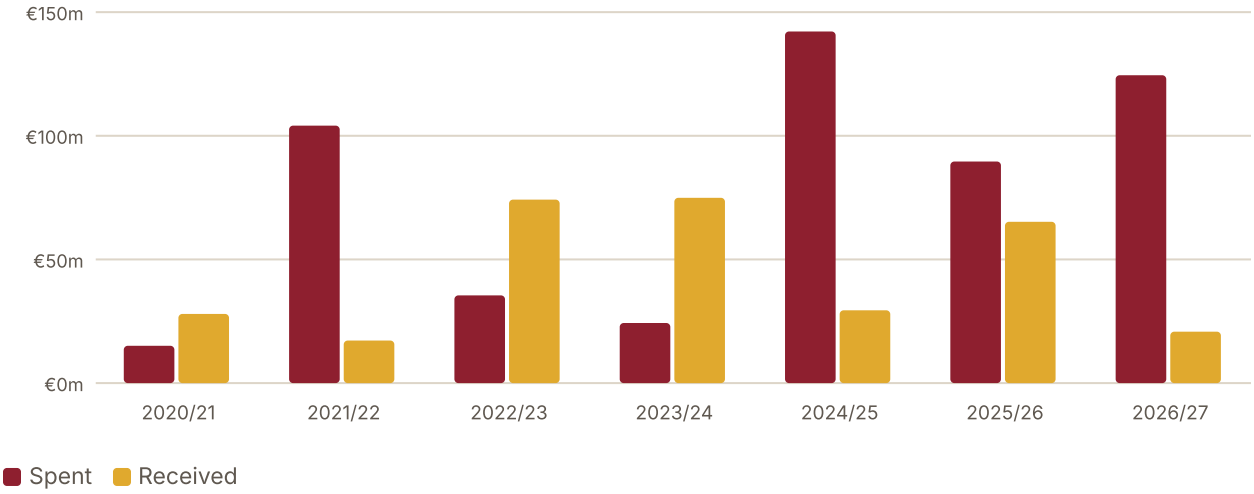
Between the 2020/21 season and the close of the summer 2026 window, Roma spent €535m on transfer fees, purchase obligations and loan fees, and received €310m, for a net spend of €226m. Table 3 and Figure 4 show three distinct phases.

Table 3. Transfer spending and income by season (€m)

Season	Head coach	Spent	Received	Net
2020/21	Fonseca	15.1	28.0	-12.9
2021/22	Mourinho	104.1	17.2	+86.9
2022/23	Mourinho	35.5	74.2	-38.7
2023/24	Mourinho / De Rossi	24.3	74.9	-50.6
2024/25	De Rossi / Jurić / Ranieri	142.2	29.4	+112.8
2025/26	Gasperini	89.6	65.2	+24.4
2026/27†	Gasperini	124.5	20.8	+103.7

† Summer 2026 window only. Purchase obligations are counted in the season paid.

Figure 4. Transfer spending and income by season, €m



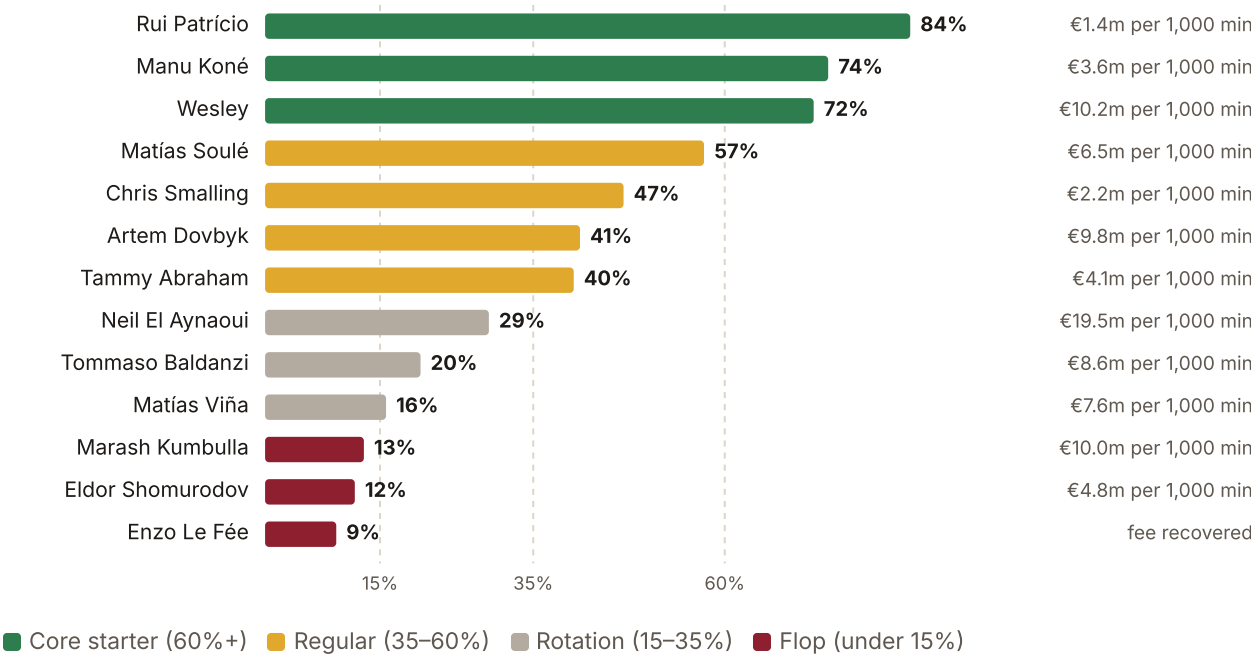
Source: Sky Sport, Salary Sport, Foot Mercato, Chiesa di Totti.

The first phase was an expansion in 2021/22, when Roma spent €104m, led by Tammy Abraham (€41m) and Eldor Shomurodov (€18m), to support José Mourinho's first season. Combined with flat revenue, this contributed to a €220m loss and the UEFA settlement. The second phase, 2022/23 to 2023/24, was a correction: Roma received more than it spent in both seasons, selling Roger Ibañez (€30m), Nicolò Zaniolo (€15.7m) and Jordan Veretout (€12.45m), and relying on free agents such as Paulo Dybala. The third phase, from 2024/25 onward, returned to heavy investment: €356m in gross spending across three seasons, despite the club remaining under the settlement agreement.

5.2 What the money bought

Figure 5 applies the minutes-share measure to the thirteen signings costing €10m or more agreed under the current ownership that Roma has owned for at least one full season. Purchase obligations agreed before the takeover, such as Roger Ibañez's, are excluded.

Figure 5. Share of available Serie A minutes played for Roma, signings of €10m or more



Seasons spent on loan elsewhere count as owned seasons. Right-hand column: net fee per 1,000 league minutes played. Source: FBref; author's calculations.

Only three of the thirteen became core starters: goalkeeper Rui Patrício (84%), midfielder Manu Koné (74%) and wing-back Wesley (72%, after a single season). Four more were regulars, including Abraham, whose €41m bought 5,516 league minutes and 33 goals and assists, concentrated in his first season. At the other end, Marash Kumbulla, Eldor Shomurodov and Enzo Le Fée cost a combined €67.5m and played 4,965 league minutes for Roma, roughly one and a half seasons of football between three players. Net cost per 1,000 minutes adds a value dimension: Patrício (€1.4m) and Chris Smalling (€2.2m) delivered the cheapest minutes, while Neil El Aynaoui (€19.5m) has so far delivered the most expensive.

5.3 The free-agent advantage

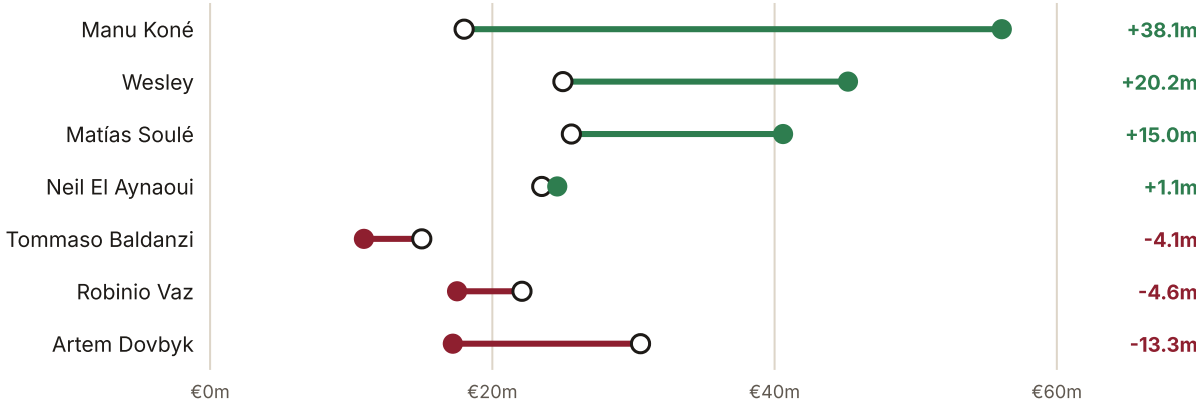
The ledger's clearest finding is where Roma's best value came from. Four players signed without a transfer fee (goalkeeper Mile Svilar, centre-back Evan Ndicka, Dybala and Henrikh Mkhitaryan) played 28,437 Serie A minutes for the club, more than five times the output of the three fee-paid flops. These players were not free, since their wages were often high, and Section 4 shows that wages are what

ultimately buy results. But free agents remove the largest single risk in a transfer, the upfront fee, which is lost entirely if a signing fails. Two of them have also become valuable assets: FotMob currently values Svilar at €41m and Ndicka at €35m.

5.4 Asset value of recent signings

Minutes measure what a signing has contributed; market value measures what the asset is now worth. Figure 6 compares the fees Roma paid for the 2024–2026 signings it still owns and has used or loaned out with their current estimated values.

Figure 6. Transfer fee paid versus current estimated market value, €m



Hollow marker: fee paid. Filled marker: FotMob estimated value, October 2026. Summer 2026 signings without Roma minutes are excluded. Market values are estimates, not prices. Source: FotMob; transfer records.

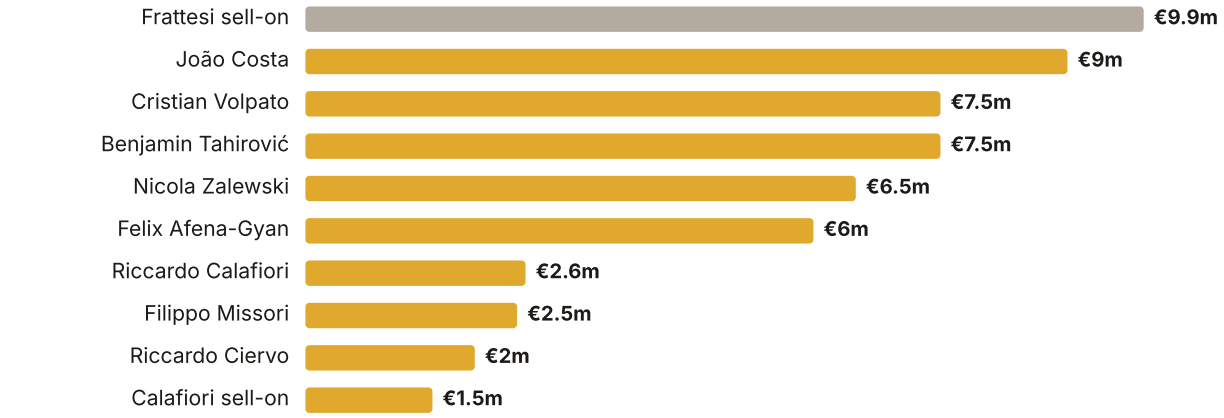
The seven signings shown cost €160m and are currently valued at about €212m. The gain is concentrated in the three most-used signings still at the club (Koné, Wesley and Soulé). Three of the four players now out on loan (Dovbyk, Vaz and Baldanzi) have lost value, which is consistent with the minutes data: assets the club does not use tend to depreciate.

6. The Academy: Profit Center or Pipeline?

6.1 Academy sales

Under Italian accounting rules, a homegrown player carries almost no book value, so nearly every euro received from a sale is recorded as a capital gain (*plusvalenza*). That makes academy sales the fastest way to improve a club's reported result. Between 2021 and 2025, Roma raised about €57m from homegrown players, including sell-on payments, equal to about 20% of all transfer income from 2020/21 to 2025/26 (Figure 7). Over a longer window, CIES Football Observatory estimates that Roma earned €131m from selling club-trained players between 2014 and 2023, third in Serie A behind Atalanta (€250m) and Inter (€134m).

Figure 7. Academy-related transfer income, €m (sales of €1.5m or more)



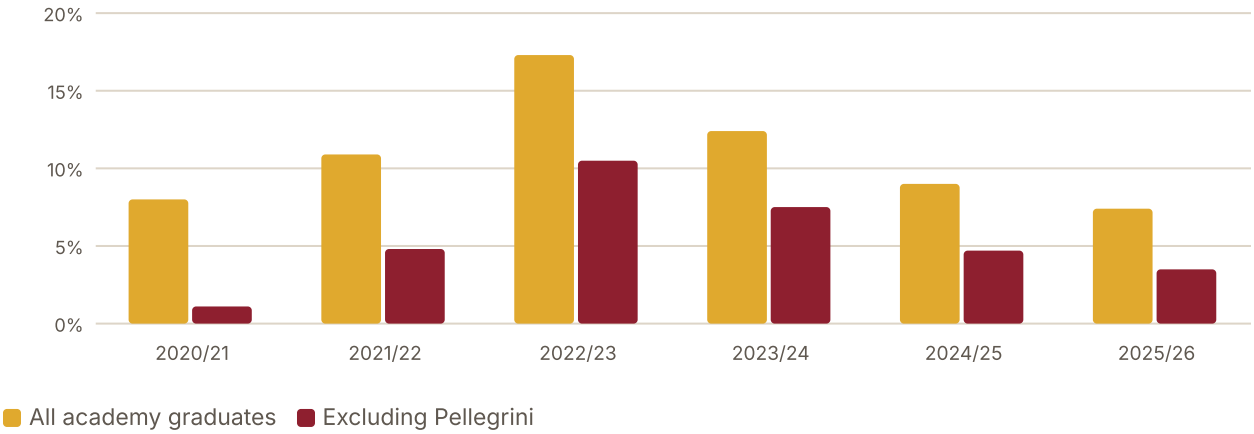
The Frattesi figure is an estimate based on a reported 30% sell-on clause. Source: Calcio e Finanza, Sky Sport, Goal, Tuttomercatoweb.

> **Case: June 2023.** Under its UEFA settlement agreement, Roma needed roughly €30m in player-sale profit before its 30 June accounting deadline. Within a few weeks it sold three academy players, Benjamin Tahirović to Ajax and Cristian Volpato and Filippo Missori to Sassuolo, for €17.5m, almost all of it recorded as profit. In that window the academy was functioning less as a talent pipeline than as a source of liquidity for regulatory compliance.

6.2 Academy usage

If the academy is also meant to supply the first team, that should appear in playing time. Figure 8 shows the share of Roma's Serie A minutes played by academy graduates in each season.

Figure 8. Share of Roma's Serie A minutes played by academy graduates



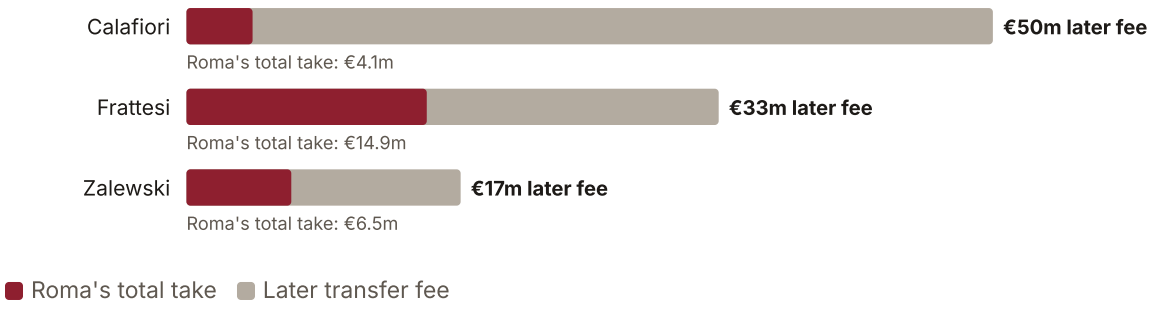
Graduates are players who came through Roma's youth sector, including Lorenzo Pellegrini, who returned in 2017. Total minutes = 38 matches × 90 × 11. CIES reported a comparable 17.8% for Roma in January 2023, first in Serie A. Source: FBref; author's calculations.

Academy minutes peaked at 17.3% in 2022/23, when Nicola Zalewski and Edoardo Bove became regulars and Roma briefly ranked first in Serie A for minutes given to club-trained players. They have since fallen to 7.4%, and excluding the captain, Lorenzo Pellegrini, to just 3.5%. Apart from Pellegrini, Niccolò Pisilli is currently the only graduate with a regular role. The two pieces of evidence point the same way: in recent seasons the academy has been used more to raise money than to build the team.

6.3 The cost of selling early

Selling academy players has a cost that does not appear in the accounts: the future value of the players sold. Figure 9 compares what Roma received for three homegrown players with the fees later paid for them.

Figure 9. Roma's total take versus each player's later transfer fee, €m



Roma's take includes sell-on payments. Frattesi was sold in 2017, before the current ownership, but illustrates the same pattern. Source: Calcio e Finanza, ANSA, Goal.

Riccardo Calafiori is the extreme case. Roma sold him to Basel in 2022 for €2.6m, retaining a 40% sell-on clause. He moved to Bologna for €4m a year later and to Arsenal for about €50m in 2024. Roma has received €4.1m in total and has pursued a further €6–9m through the Court of Arbitration for Sport, arguing that its clause applies to Basel's own sell-on income. Across Calafiori, Davide Frattesi and Zalewski, buyers captured about €75m of value that Roma did not. Some sales were financially necessary, but the drafting of sell-on clauses and the timing of sales carry real economic weight: the 30% clause on Frattesi produced roughly €9.9m, more than any single outright academy sale in the period.

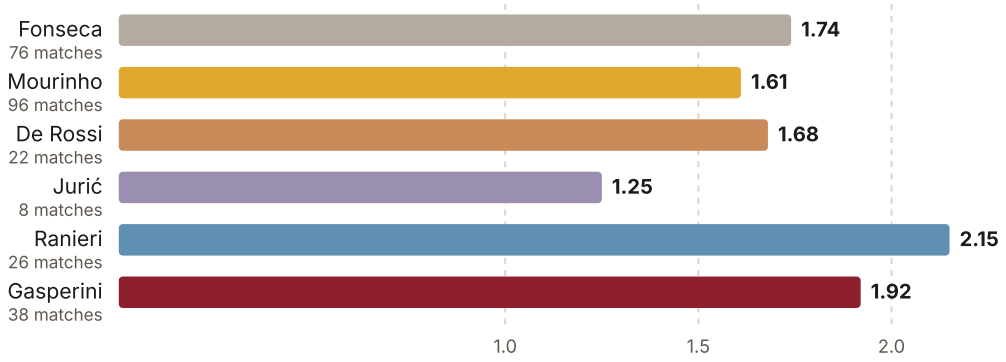
7. On-Pitch Performance

7.1 Results by manager

Roma employed Paulo Fonseca, José Mourinho, Daniele De Rossi, Ivan Jurić, Claudio Ranieri and Gasperini between 2019 and 2026. Figure 10 compares their Serie A points per game, and Table 4 lists the season records. Mourinho's 1.61 was the lowest of the established managers, despite his European

success; De Rossi (1.68) and Ranieri (2.15) improved on it over shorter spells, and Gasperini reached 1.92 over a full season.

Figure 10. Serie A points per game by head coach

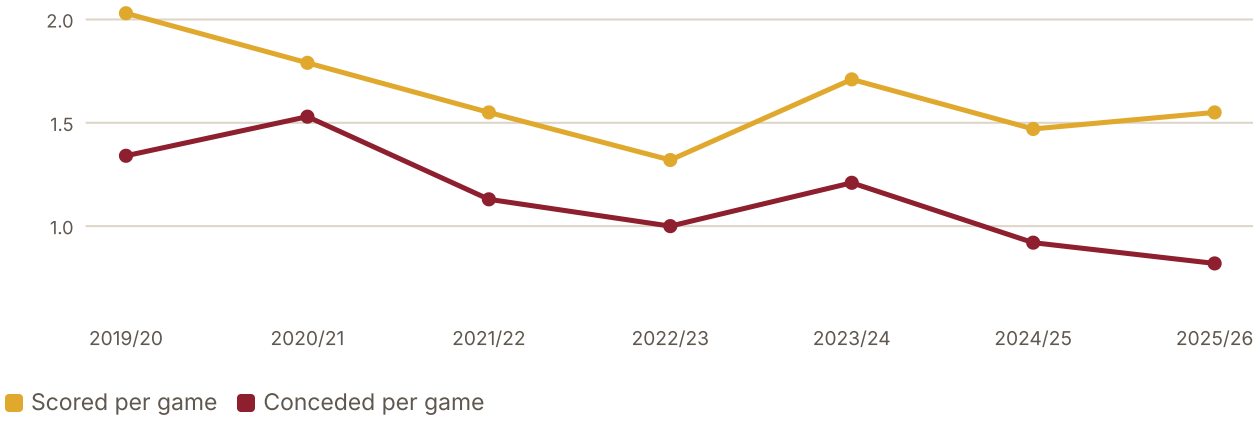


Short tenures (Jurić, De Rossi, Ranieri) are small samples. Source: FBref and Wikipedia season records; author's calculations.

Table 4. Serie A results by season

Season	Head coach	Rank	W–D–L	GF–GA	Pts
2019/20	Fonseca	5	21–7–10	77–51	70
2020/21	Fonseca	7	18–8–12	68–58	62
2021/22	Mourinho	6	18–9–11	59–43	63
2022/23	Mourinho	6	18–9–11	50–38	63
2023/24	Mourinho → De Rossi	6	18–9–11	65–46	63
2024/25	De Rossi → Jurić → Ranieri	5	20–9–9	56–35	69
2025/26	Gasperini	3	23–4–11	59–31	73

Figure 11. Goals scored and conceded per game, by season



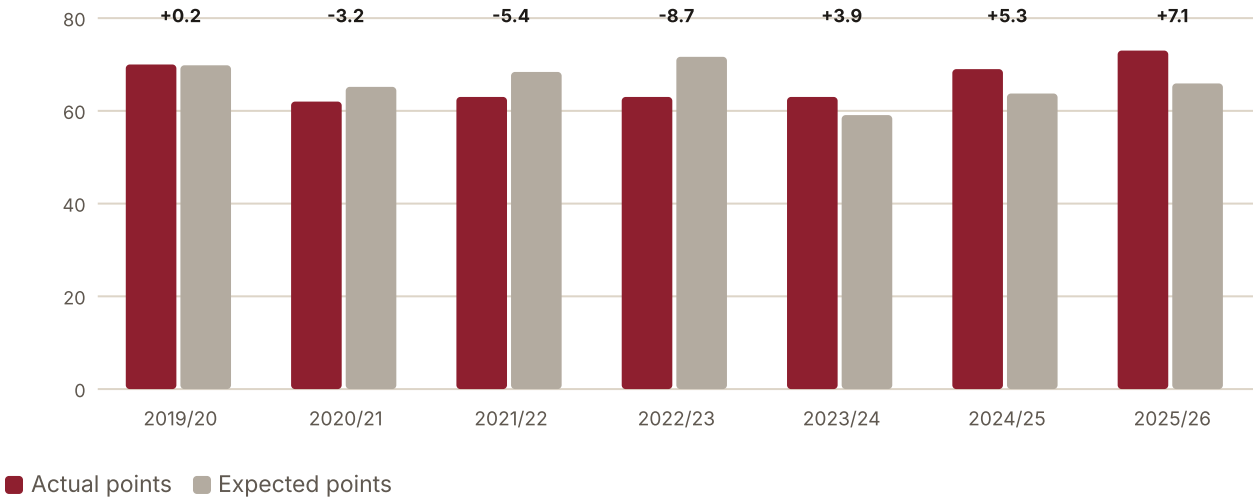
Source: FBref.

Three styles emerge from Figure 11. Fonseca's teams were open: they scored 2.0 goals per game in 2019/20 but conceded 1.53 per game in 2020/21, the worst of the period. Mourinho's teams were low-event: they conceded less but scored only 50 league goals in 2022/23, the lowest total of the period. Their success came in knockout European football, with a Conference League title and a Europa League final, while league points stayed at 63 in each full season. Gasperini's 2025/26 team improved both ends at once: 23 wins and only 31 goals conceded (0.82 per game), the best defensive record in the period.

7.2 Underlying performance

Results contain a large element of chance. Figure 12 compares Roma's actual points with its expected points based on the quality of chances created and conceded.

Figure 12. Actual points versus expected points by season



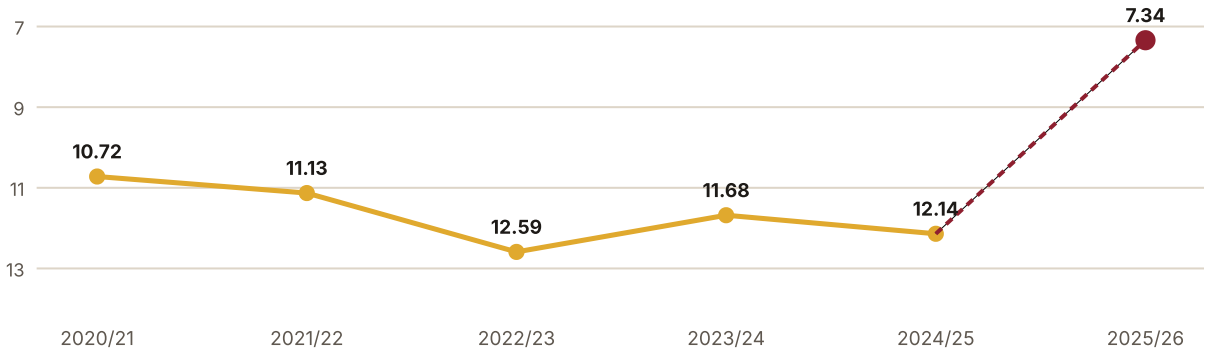
2019/20–2023/24: expected points simulated match by match from Understat shot xG. 2024/25–2025/26: fitted from a league-wide regression of points on xG difference (StatMuse xG). The two methods are not identical; compare within each period. Value above each pair: actual minus expected.

Two seasons stand out. In 2022/23 Mourinho's team created and conceded chances worth about 72 points, the strongest underlying record of any season simulated from shot data, but finished with 63, after scoring well below its expected goals and conceding slightly more than expected. On this evidence the team's league position understated its underlying quality; fourth place required 70 points that season. In the opposite direction, Roma outperformed its underlying numbers in 2024/25 and again in 2025/26, when its xG difference ranked 4th in Serie A, behind Inter, Juventus and Como, and implied about 66 points against the 73 achieved. Combined with Section 4, this suggests that Gasperini's first season delivered results in line with the wage bill while the underlying performance was still catching up. The early evidence from 2026/27 is encouraging: after five matches Roma had an xG difference of about +7.7 and had conceded just over five expected goals.

7.3 Pressing

The clearest stylistic change under Gasperini is pressing intensity. Figure 13 shows Roma's PPDA by season.

Figure 13. Roma's PPDA by season (lower = more aggressive pressing)



2020/21–2024/25: full-season values from Understat as compiled by Assoanalisti. 2025/26: matchdays 1–10 only, same source family. Gazzetta dello Sport reported a full-season 2025/26 PPDA of 10.3 (2nd in Serie A) using a different provider. Source: Assoanalisti; Gazzetta dello Sport.

Before Gasperini, Roma were a middling pressing side: among the twelve clubs present in Serie A in every season from 2020/21 to 2024/25, Roma ranked between seventh and tenth for PPDA each year. In 2025/26 Roma ranked second in Serie A for PPDA in the measures available here and recorded the most pressed sequences in the league (476, according to Opta). After five matches of 2026/27, Opta again ranked Roma second in Serie A (PPDA 9.9, behind Frosinone), while SofaScore's measure (8.54) placed Roma lowest across Europe's top five leagues. The defensive improvement described in Section 7.1 coincided with this much more aggressive press, which is consistent with a team defending by winning the ball higher up the pitch rather than by sitting deeper.

7.4 Squad age

Table 5. Roma squad age by season

Season	Minutes-weighted age (FBref)	Age of players fielded, Roma (CIES)	Serie A average (CIES)
2020/21	26.7	–	–
2021/22	–	26.31	27.24
2022/23	27.4	28.14	26.92
2023/24	27.7	28.69	26.77
2024/25	26.5	–	–
2025/26	26.3	26.52	26.86

CIES figures are early-season snapshots (September–October); the Serie A average is the mean of the 20 clubs. Source: FBref; CIES Football Observatory via Sky Sport and Panorama.

Roma were one of Serie A's oldest teams in 2022 and 2023, fielding players one to two years older than the league average. Since 2024 the squad has been rebuilt younger, and by 2025/26 its minutes-weighted age had fallen to 26.3, slightly below the league average. A younger core matters for both performance and asset value, because players in their early-to-mid twenties are both entering their peak years and holding their resale value, as the gains on Koné and Wesley illustrate.

8. Applying the Findings: A Recruitment Decision

Analysis is most useful when it supports a decision. This section applies the findings to Roma's current weakest position: left wing-back. Gasperini's 3-4-2-1 system depends on wing-backs to provide width and chance creation. By autumn 2026 Roma's natural left-sided options had left: Kostas Tsimikas returned to Liverpool, Angeliño and Anass Salah-Eddine were loaned out, and Wesley, a right-back, had been covering the position. The club's first-choice target, Matteo Ruggeri, joined Aston Villa in August, and a deal for Jayden Oosterwolde stalled after a medical. A natural left wing-back would also move Wesley back to his strongest side, improving two positions with one signing.

The earlier sections shape the search criteria. Section 3 limits the budget, since Roma remains under UEFA monitoring. Section 5 favours signings who will be used and who hold their value, and Section 7.4 shows the benefit of a younger core; together with the commonly observed peak window for full-backs, this points toward players aged 24–28 who are already established in a top league. Section 7 defines the profile: a left-footed wing-back who creates chances in a high-tempo pressing system. Six candidates were scored on six weighted criteria: chance creation, measured as expected assists per 90 (20 points) and chances created per 90 (10); cost relative to estimated market value (20); feasibility, meaning whether the selling club would realistically deal with Roma (20); current availability (15); and fit with the commonly observed peak window for full-backs of ages 24–28 (15).

Table 6. Left wing-back shortlist, ranked by weighted score

#	Player	Age	Club	Value	xA/90	Chances/90	Score
1	Juan Miranda	26	Bologna	€14.7m	0.16	2.57	**86**
2	Josh Doig	24	Sassuolo	€4.8m	0.05	1.09	**79**
3	Nuno Tavares	26	Lazio	€14.6m	0.23	1.59	**70**
4	Fabiano Parisi	25	Fiorentina	€7m	0.10	1.12	**69**
5	Maxim De Cuyper	25	Brighton	€24.9m	0.14	2.33	**65**
6	Jayden Oosterwolde	25	Fenerbahçe	€15.4m	–	–	**57**

Per-90 figures use 2026/27 data (4–5 matches) except Parisi, scored on 2025/26 because he is injured. Oosterwolde has no expected-assists data. Source: FotMob, October 2026; author's model.

Juan Miranda of Bologna ranks first with 86 points. He is the only candidate who scores well on every criterion at once: a natural left-back, fit, valued at about €15m, already established as a starter in Serie A, and the group's most frequent chance creator at 2.6 chances per 90. Josh Doig of Sassuolo (79) is the value alternative at about €5m. The model also explains why stronger individual profiles rank lower. Nuno Tavares has the best expected-assists rate but plays for Lazio, Roma's city rival, which makes a direct sale unrealistic. Maxim De Cuyper is the most complete attacker but is priced as a Premier League starter. Fabiano Parisi is recovering from a cruciate ligament injury, and Oosterwolde is primarily a centre-back. The recommendation is to make Miranda the primary January target, with Doig as the fallback.

9. Discussion

Taken together, the six lenses describe a club whose spending was large enough to compete near the top of Serie A, but whose decisions often converted that spending poorly. Roma paid a top-four wage bill throughout the period, yet until 2025/26 finished below the level that wage bill predicts. The 2021/22 spending wave bought players who mostly failed to become starters, deepened the club's losses and contributed to the UEFA settlement, which in turn pushed the club toward early sales of academy players. The most reliable returns came from the least expensive channel, the free-agent market. The shortfall against the wage bill closed in 2024/25 and held under Gasperini, whose clearer tactical identity and younger recruits also transformed the club's pressing and lifted the value of its squad.

Four implications follow for a club in Roma's position. First, **benchmark against wages, not just against last season.** A third-place finish looks like success in isolation, but it is par for Roma's wage bill; the useful question is how many points above or below expectation the club finishes, and why. Second, **measure signings by usage and asset value, not only by headline fee.** A simple minutes-share metric would have flagged Kumbulla's and Shomurodov's low returns early, while the cost of correcting

course was still small. Third, **treat the academy as both a financial and a sporting asset.** Sell-on clauses deserve the same analytical attention as headline fees, and selling graduates before their value peaks should be a deliberate choice rather than a reflex driven by accounting deadlines. Fourth, **separate results from underlying performance.** Expected-goals data showed that Mourinho's 2022/23 team was better than its league position and that Gasperini's 2025/26 team was worse than its; decisions about coaches and squads should rest on the underlying numbers, which are more stable from season to season.

The financial constraint frames everything else. With wages still at about two-thirds of revenue and the club under UEFA monitoring, Roma cannot spend its way past Inter, Milan and Juventus. Its realistic path to sustained top-four status is to keep converting wages into points at least at the league-average rate, to continue buying younger players who hold their value, and to complete the Pietralata stadium, which is the only lever large enough to change the club's revenue position.

10. Limitations and Further Work

- **Wage data are pre-season estimates** of gross contracted wages, compiled from three different outlets across the four seasons, and exclude bonuses and January moves. Comparisons within a season are more reliable than comparisons across seasons. Wage data for 2021/22 were not available for all clubs, so that season is excluded from the model.
- **Expected-goals providers differ.** Understat's xG runs systematically higher than Opta's, so the two methods in Figure 12 should be compared within each period, not across them. Expected points for 2019/20–2023/24 were simulated from shot data rather than taken from a published source.
- **Pressing data are incomplete.** A full-season 2025/26 PPDA from the same provider as earlier seasons was not available, and no full 20-club PPDA rankings were found before 2025/26.
- **Transfer fees are reported, not audited,** and market values are model-based estimates, not prices. The Frattesi sell-on is an estimate.
- **Minutes measure usage, not quality,** and the signing tier thresholds are a modelling choice.
- **The recruitment model uses small samples** for most candidates, and its feasibility and availability scores are judgment calls. It should be read as a first screen.

Natural extensions include adding wage data for earlier seasons to cover the full Friedkin era; replacing the market-value comparison with book values from the club's accounts; building a league-wide model of pressing intensity and points to test whether Roma's experience generalises; and extending the recruitment screen to a full-season database of 30–50 left-backs with position-specific age curves.

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